

journey. Career guidance, industry interactions, internships and recruitment support are integrated into every programme from the start.

- **Careers, Not Certificates** - The true measure of success is not the number of students who complete training, but the number who begin meaningful careers with confidence, dignity and financial independence.

PROOF THAT THE MODEL WORKS

The Convocation of Multi Skill Development Centre by Sun Foundation at Ludhiana held on 16 July 2026 brought this philosophy to life.

In the presence of Shri Jayant Chaudhary, Hon'ble Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Skill Development & Entrepreneurship, and Shri Gulab Chand Kataria, Hon'ble Governor of Punjab, graduating trainees received their NSDC mark sheets. The defining moment, however, came when 1,044 appointment letters were handed over by leading employers like Taj, Sportking, Shahi Exports, Max Hospitals, OCM, Happy Forgings , Encalm, Indigo, Axis Bank and such

For many families, those appointment letters represented far more than employment—they marked the beginning of financial independence, stability and hope.

A MODEL BUILT FOR SCALE

Established in 1998, Sun Foundation has evolved into one of India's leading not-for-profit institutions dedicated to employability-driven skilling. Today, it operates seven major Skill Development Centres across Delhi, Ludhiana, Amritsar, Patiala, Faridkot , Hoshiarpur and Pahuwind, collectively training and providing jobs to over 5,000 youth every year.

The programs span advanced manufacturing, logistics, healthcare, hospitality, customer service, digital technologies and emerging sectors like AI , CNC Machining, Junior Nurse, assistant fashion designing. Every trainee also receives communication skills, digital literacy and placement support.

The objective is to prepare young people for sustainable careers in an evolving economy.

BEYOND SKILLING: INVESTING IN HUMAN POTENTIAL

Sun Foundation's commitment extends beyond vocational training to broader social transformation.

Through its **Surya Kiran** rural livelihood initiative, the Foundation has empowered more than 25,000 rural women across Punjab and Haryana. The initiative's impact has been independently validated through a PwC Social Impact Assessment.

The Foundation also supports meritorious students from economically weaker backgrounds through its Angels of Sun scholarship programme, enabling them to pursue higher education in medicine, engineering, aviation, research, sports and the arts.

Dr. Vikram Sahney has also adopted 10 Government Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) across Punjab, upgrading them with Industry 4.0 infrastructure, including robotic welding, 3D printing, CNC machining and automation, aligned with modern industry needs.

At Sun Foundation Skills are tools for 'Social Transformation', perhaps the strongest testament to this philosophy lies beyond conventional classrooms.

Recognising that lasting rehabilitation requires sustainable livelihoods, Sun Foundation has introduced holistic development programmes, combining free skill training with yoga, music therapy and life skills, across 12 Drug De-addiction and Rehabilitation Centres in Punjab.

The initiative demonstrates that skill development is not only an economic intervention, but also a powerful instrument of social transformation.

PUNJAB'S OPPORTUNITY

For Dr. Vikramjit Singh Sahney, whose roots lie in Kotkapura, Faridkot, this mission is deeply personal. Having risen from humble beginnings, he has witnessed both Punjab's extraordinary strengths and its changing realities.

Once India's agricultural and manufacturing powerhouse, Punjab today faces slowing industrial growth, migration and youth unemployment. For many families, unemployment, overseas migration and, in some cases, drug addiction have become difficult realities.

Today, as Punjab strives to attract fresh investments, strengthen its manufacturing base, expand logistics infrastructure, and diversify its economy, such initiatives can be true game changers.

Punjab needs many more such collaborative initiatives.

A SHARED NATIONAL RESPONSIBILITY

India's skill challenge cannot be addressed by any single institution.

Government must continue providing policy direction. Industry must define emerging competencies and create employment opportunities. Training institutions must deliver high-quality, market-aligned education. Corporate India can contribute through CSR partnerships and by expanding apprenticeships under the National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme (NAPS), enabling youth to gain valuable on-the-job training and industry exposure.

The greatest impact will come when these stakeholders work together with a common objective—creating employability at scale.

FROM SKILLS TO SALARIES

India's demographic dividend will not be realised through policy announcements alone. It will be realised when every young Indian leaves a classroom with skills that industry values and every employer gains access to talent that is ready from Day One.

The applause that echoed across the Ludhiana campus celebrated possibility, dignity and economic independence.

Most importantly, it was a reminder that the true success of skill development is not measured by the number of certificates issued. It is measured by the number of careers created.

That is the journey—from Skills to Salaries. And that journey has the potential to transform not only individual lives, but also Punjab's economy and India's future.